What horrifies me – no, let's say disgusts me – is people, or more precisely people in power, those at the 'top' of society. The more I see of them the more I want to resign from the world. That's why I live as a virtual recluse, only reachable by an eight-day wagon ride. I don't think the situation today is any worse than it has been over the centuries; the people at the top are still the same.

Judge Dredd is an antihero, a villain even sometimes, in an authoritarian horror future. Do you think that sense of anarchic satire will be evident to film goers and new readers, or will he be seen as a hero?

Satire's not a major element in the story. Dredd's pretty much the hero here, but a hero with an edge, a man with first-class honours in intimidation. It comes over in the way that Karl holds himself and in Alex's nicely terse dialogue.

'America' is one of the most political stories. What was the motivation behind that arc? Could you see it being a good story for a film?

In 'America', I wanted to cover a broad swathe of Mega-City life, to present a truly rounded picture of how things are. It was designed for the launch of the *Judge Dredd Megazine*. The feeling was the lead *Dredd* story had to be something special, a more 'adult' view of Dredd's world – as good, I was told, as *The Dark Knight Returns* ("c'mon, guy, you can do it!"). I'm not making any claims in that direction – *Batman: Year One* was the better story anyway. In fact, it's my all-time favourite comic story – but I do take a certain pleasure that the late Pete Root, no bad judge, once told me 'America' was the best strip he'd ever read.

You can't, of course, minimise the part Colin MacNeil's wonderful art played in the process. Without it, would 'America' be remembered so fondly? I doubt it. It's a real boost for a writer to work with an artist so committed to a story, and – horribly overused phrase – truly at the peak of his powers. It's one of those stories, where it's simply wrong to say 'Wagner's America'. It has to be Wagner and MacNeil, Wagner and [Arthur] Ranson. They were true collaborations.

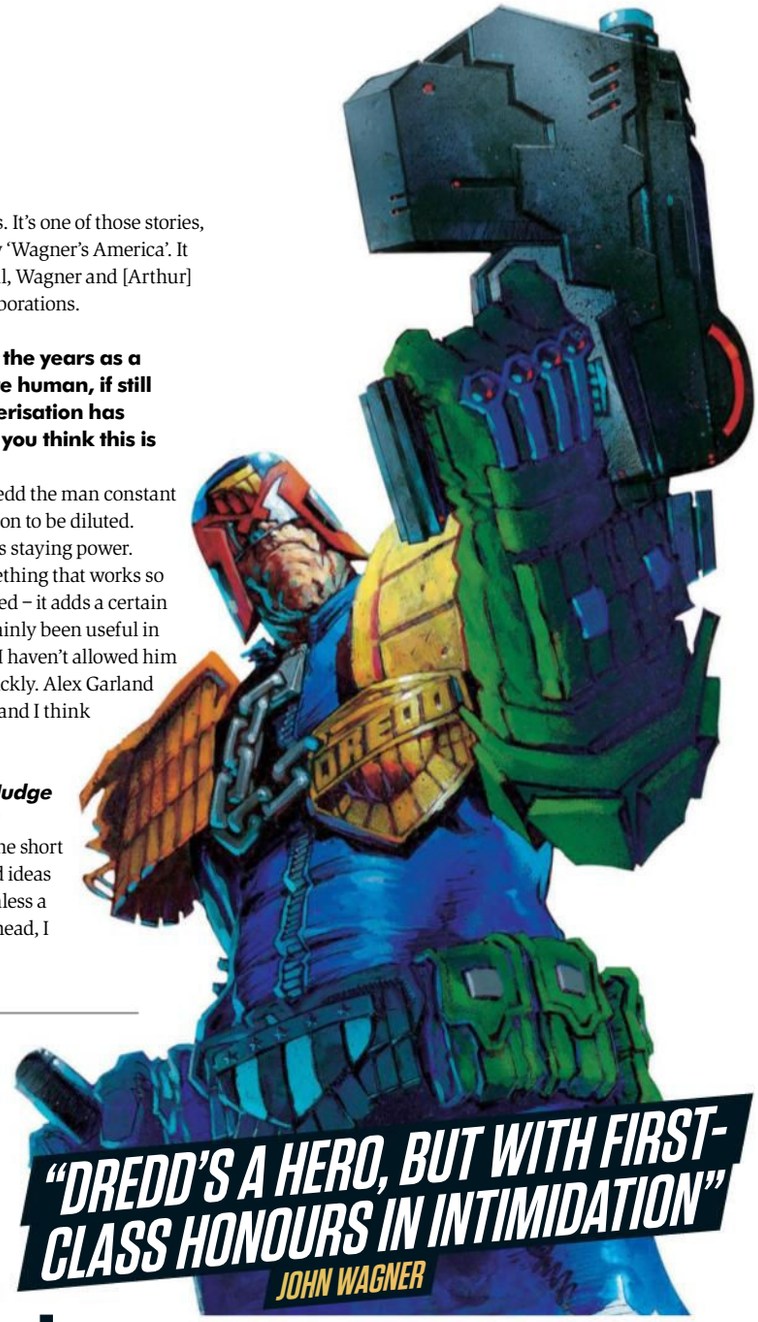
Dredd has changed over the years as a character, becoming more human, if still hard-edged. His characterisation has always been central – do you think this is key to his longevity?

I've always striven to keep Dredd the man constant and not allow the original vision to be diluted. That may be the real key to his staying power. Why screw around with something that works so well? So though he has changed – it adds a certain spice to things and it has certainly been useful in terms of story development – I haven't allowed him to change too much or too quickly. Alex Garland described the pace as glacial, and I think that's quite fast enough.

Is it challenging writing *Judge Dredd* after all this time?

You bet. It's much harder on the short stories, especially to find good ideas or new angles. These days, unless a promising idea pops into my head, I prefer to leave them to other, fresher minds.

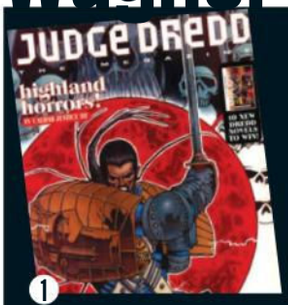
A near complete run of John Wagner's work can be found collected in Rebellion's ongoing *Judge Dredd: The Complete Case Files*, as well as weekly in *2000 AD* and monthly in the *Judge Dredd Megazine*.



"DREDD'S A HERO, BUT WITH FIRST-CLASS HONOURS IN INTIMIDATION"
JOHN WAGNER

Wagner's Most Wanted

The co-creator's five favourite storylines and their sequel potential...



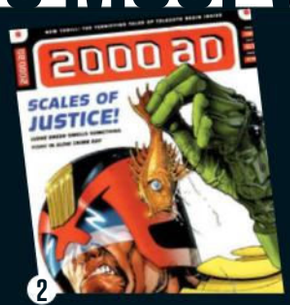
1

BURY MY KNEE AT WOUNDED HEART

Writer: John Wagner
Artist: Peter Doherty

If anyone tells you *Judge Dredd* strips can't convey emotion, give them this to read. It is often regarded by fans as the best story in Dredd history.

First appeared in *Judge Dredd Megazine* Volume 2 issue 46.



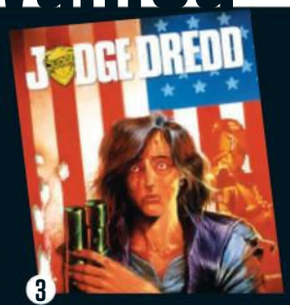
2

SLOW CRIME DAY

Writer: John Wagner
Artist: Peter Doherty

A single episode where the Judges go berserk after momentarily running out of crime. The art is fantastic, with the cover featuring Dredd threatening the readers, "Buy this comic or the fish gets it!"

Appeared in *2000 AD* prog 1,191.



3

AMERICA

Writer: John Wagner
Artist: Colin MacNeil

"'America' probably would make a good film" enthuses Wagner. "It may be a thought he [Alex Garland] is toying with, but there's so much to choose from that I doubt he'd tie himself down."

Collected in *Judge Dredd: America*, priced £11.99



4

NECROPOLIS

Writer: John Wagner
Artist: Carlos Ezquerra

The ultimate Judge Death saga and another potential sequel candidate. "On a visual level Death would be great," Wagner says, "but I'd understand if Alex decided not to go that way."

Collected in *Judge Dredd: The Complete Case Files 14* at £18.99.



5

BLOCK MANIA

Writers: John Wagner, Alan Grant
Artists: Mike McMahon, Brian Bolland

This classic block war gone wrong story is a timely read. The tension is high and the claustrophobia suffocating, but there's more to this than action.

Collected in *Judge Dredd: The Complete Case Files 5*, priced £13.99